



OFF-SIDE

Ayon Sengupta

sportstar@thehindu.co.in



DRAWN APART

Every World Cup promises that the **best team** will earn its place at the summit. Yet in 2026, the route to that summit appears far from equal.

Every great sporting competition is built on an unspoken promise. It asks athletes and teams to accept that fortune will always play a part. Ultimately, though, the tournament structure must guarantee a fair and equitable playing field. Every nation that qualifies for the knockout rounds should inherit a relatively similar, equally challenging path to glory.

For nearly a century, that promise has underpinned the FIFA World Cup. FIFA's new 48-team format has undoubtedly achieved its objectives. More countries have reached football's biggest stage. More supporters have travelled across North America. Forty additional matches have also created unprecedented commercial opportunities.

Yet, as the Round of 32 rolls on, we are left to ponder whether the 2026 knockout draw has fundamentally broken that promise of an even-handed route to the final week of the tournament.

One half of the bracket contains eight of FIFA's top 11-ranked nations (according to the June 11 official rankings): Spain (2), France (3), Portugal (5), Morocco (7), the Netherlands (8), Belgium (9), Germany (10), and Croatia (11), with the likes of Senegal (15), the United States (17), Austria (24), Canada (30), Sweden (38), Paraguay (41), South Africa (60), and Bosnia and Herzegovina (64) joining them.

The other half, featuring Argentina (1), England (4), and Brazil (6), followed by Colombia (13), Mexico (14), Japan (18), Switzerland (19), Ecuador (23), Australia (27), Algeria (28), Egypt (29), Norway (31), Côte d'Ivoire (33), DR Congo (46), Cape Verde (67),

and Ghana (73), looks relatively easier compared to the top team-heavy side of the bracket.

No World Cup draw is ever perfectly balanced. But the expansion from 32 to 48 teams has made those imbalances more pronounced.

Like every World Cup, the knockout bracket was determined long before the opening game. But in a 48-team tournament, with 12 groups and eight third-placed teams also advancing, the consequences are magnified.

A group winner can find itself entering the stronger half of the draw, while another team that finishes second, or even advances as one of the best third-placed sides, can inherit a significantly less demanding path simply because of where its group feeds into the bracket.

Belgium (9), winner of Group G, faces high-ranked Senegal (15) in the Round of 32, while second-placed Egypt has a relatively easier opponent in Australia, ranked 27. Group F champion the Netherlands takes on last edition's semifinalist Morocco, which is ranked a spot ahead of it, while Colombia, the USA, and England, also group winners, face relatively weaker teams in Ghana, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and DR Congo, which are ranked 60, 47, and 42 places below them, respectively.

When the luck of the draw completely replaces the principle of competitive equity, the integrity of the tournament will inevitably be questioned. For the World Cup to remain a true test of the world's best, every qualified nation must step onto a similarly challenging battlefield, not one defined by a predetermined trap or a preordained route to the top.